

Why Formora makes money *in the AI age*

AI made building a website almost free. It did not make being found, being trusted and being up to date free. That gap is the business.

People will pay to look good, be found and stay current, not to “build a website”.

Anyone can now ask an AI to write a web page. Very few people can then host it on their own address, keep it true as their career changes, get it chosen by AI assistants when clients ask for recommendations, and look like the best person in their field doing it. Formora sells exactly those things, mostly by subscription.

\$3.6bn

website-builder market in 2026,
growing about 17% a year
(industry estimate)

\$1.99bn

Wix's 2025 revenue, from a
product most people use once a
year

\$7.2bn

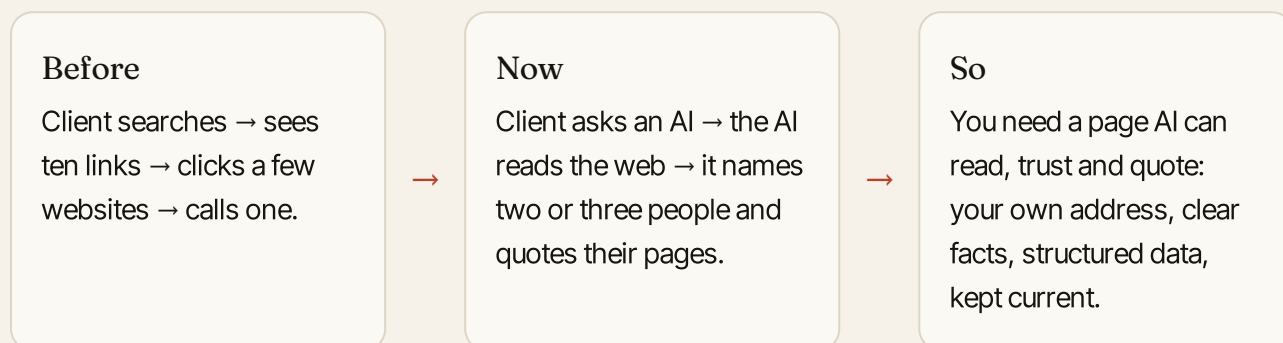
what Permira paid for
Squarespace in October 2024

Five reasons it can make money

- **The buyer is huge and under-served.** Tens of millions of professionals (agents, doctors, lawyers, teachers, trades, freelancers) need a personal site, and builders were made for designers and shops.
- **AI shifted the value from building to being chosen.** When clients ask ChatGPT or Google's AI for “a good buyer's agent in Westport”, the answer is drawn from pages like the ones Formora publishes.
- **“Kept up to date” is a reason to keep paying.** Inspector Iqbal checks your profiles on a schedule and updates the site. A one-off AI page can't do that.
- **Costs stay tiny while AI cost is passed on.** A hosted portfolio costs cents a month to serve; AI is sold at cost + 5% or runs on the customer's own Claude or OpenAI key, so heavy AI users never lose us money.
- **Free is the marketing.** Free Basic accounts and free downloadable templates spread the brand at almost no cost; Pro, domains and done-for-you set-ups earn the money.

AI turned the website from a brochure into a source.

For twenty years a personal website was a brochure: people found it through Google's blue links and read it. In 2026 more and more questions are answered directly by AI. Industry trackers estimate that around two-thirds of Google searches now end without a click, and well over 80% of searches that show an AI Overview do. ChatGPT alone reports over a billion monthly users.



That is good news for a builder that does it properly. Social profiles are often hidden behind logins and can't be read by AI search; LinkedIn shows little to logged-out visitors. A person's own website on their own domain, with clean structured data (Formora already publishes schema.org markup for people, reviews and blog posts), is the most quotable thing they can own.

The less people click, the more it matters what the AI finds when it reads about you. Formora's job is to make sure it finds something good, true and recent.

What AI did not make free

JOB	CAN A CHATBOT DO IT ALONE?	FORMORA
Write a page of copy	YES	Also does it, but it isn't the product
A design that suits the job and looks expensive	SOMETIMES	156 job titles, 51 designs, a real estate collection
Host it on your own domain, with HTTPS, renewals and email	NO	Domains at cost, automatic certificates
Keep it true as your career changes	NO	Inspector Iqbal checks on a schedule
Blog, gallery, reviews, booking	NO	Built in, every plan
Be readable and quotable by AI search	RARELY	Structured data on every page

Professionals whose next client checks them online first.

Designers and developers already have portfolios. The bigger, quieter market is everyone else whose income depends on trust: estate agents, doctors and therapists, lawyers and accountants, teachers and tutors, trades, chefs, coaches, consultants and freelancers of every kind.

~2 million

licensed real estate agents in the US alone (about 1.5 million are NAR members), most with only a brokerage profile page

160 million+

people in the US and Europe doing some independent work (McKinsey estimate); the US alone counts tens of millions of freelancers

Why real estate first

Agents spend heavily on marketing because one sale pays thousands in commission. A site that wins one extra listing pays for decades of Pro. The new real estate collection (Skyline, Manor, Front Door, Shoreline, Off Plan) has the tools agents actually sell with: valuation requests, viewing requests by WhatsApp, currency and mortgage calculators, availability for new builds. Those features are visual, so they demo well in short TikTok and Instagram videos, which is where agents spend their time.

Then every other job

The same engine serves 156 job titles. Each title has its own sample content and its own landing page (*/for/<job>*), which are search pages in their own right: “portfolio website for physiotherapists” is a query with buyers behind it and little competition.

A narrow audience that earns well from trust is easier to reach and readier to pay than “everyone who needs a website”.

Small, honest prices on many accounts, plus services for the few who want them.

STREAM	PRICE TODAY	MARGIN	ROLE
Basic (one portfolio, blog, the Investigator)	Free	—	The funnel: sign-ups, word of mouth, “Made with Formora” on every free site
Pro (three portfolios, own domain, no branding)	\$6 a month or \$60 a year	HIGH	The main profit. Hosting a site costs cents a month
AI credits (assistant, imports, Investigator)	AI cost + 5%; card fee shown separately	THIN	Covers cost, can’t lose money. Customers can also use their own Claude or OpenAI key
Domains	Registrar price + card fee	NONE	Removes friction; keeps customers renewing with us
Custom (a personal designer, booked through a free call)	<i>Quoted on the call</i>	HIGH	Custom design requirements, 50+ designs to start from, free stock photos, any section added or changed; we build it and keep it up to date

Pro at \$6 a month is still an easy yes for a professional and well below Wix and Squarespace (about \$16–20 a month for a personal site on your own domain), while being high enough that card fees stay small and the product reads as serious. Yearly (\$60, two months free) is the default. Free demo calls let hesitant buyers see it before paying, and the Custom plan turns the most demanding customers into the most profitable ones.

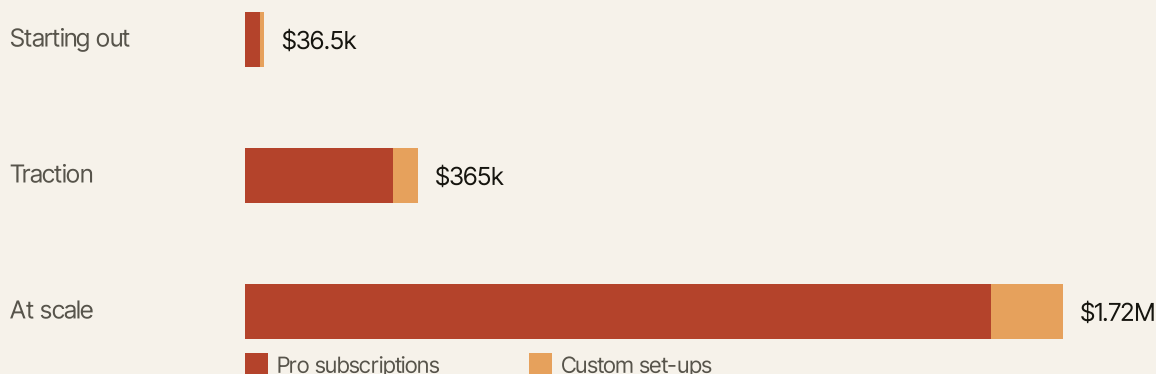
What one Pro customer costs us

- Hosting and bandwidth: a few cents a month on a shared server (one server can host thousands of portfolios).
- Card fees: about \$2 on a \$60 yearly payment (3%), and about 47¢ on each \$6 monthly payment (8%), which is why yearly is the default.
- AI: paid by the customer, either through credits at cost + 5% or on their own key. The free first Investigator check is the one AI cost we carry, and it is capped by a daily budget.

Three scenarios, with the assumptions shown.

These are illustrations, not forecasts. They assume an average of \$63 a year per Pro customer (most paying \$60 yearly, some \$6 monthly), and a Custom set-up price of \$249 as a placeholder until you set the real one. At \$6 a month fewer free users may upgrade than at \$2.50, so watch conversion closely. AI and domains are treated as break-even.

SCENARIO	FREE ACCOUNTS	PRO CUSTOMERS	SET-UPS A YEAR	REVENUE A YEAR
Starting out	12,000	500	20	≈ \$36,500
Traction	120,000	5,000	200	≈ \$365,000
At scale	600,000	25,000	600	≈ \$1,724,000



The number that decides everything

Free-to-paid conversion. Freemium products typically convert 2–5% of free users. The scenarios above assume about 4%. Three levers move it: the own-domain and no-branding benefits (status), the three-portfolio limit (people with more than one role), and a free first Investigator check that shows the site keeping itself current, which is hard to give up once seen.

Running costs are small: a server of about \$40–100 a month carries the first scenarios; email, monitoring and backups add tens of dollars. The biggest cost is your time, which is why the product is built to run itself.

What a competitor, or a chatbot, can't copy in a weekend.

1. It keeps working after it's built

The Investigator turns a one-off purchase into an ongoing service: new job, new talk, new award, and the site updates itself. Customers stay because the site stays true.

2. Designs made for the job

156 job titles and 51 studio designs, including a real estate collection with working calculators, valuations and availability. Generic AI builders produce generic pages.

3. Distribution built in

Free sites carry "Made with Formora"; free templates spread through the gallery; job-title pages rank in search; demo videos travel on social media.

4. No AI lock-in

Customers can use credits (Claude) or their own Claude or OpenAI key, and ChatGPT and Codex users bring the account they already pay for. If AI prices fall, customers benefit; if a better model appears, it can be added.

5. Trust and security

Verified sign-in, encrypted keys, strict limits, audited dependencies, security headers and a hardened server. Professionals trust you with their name, and that has to be earned.

6. The next step: AI agents as a channel

The plan's connector ("update my site from ChatGPT or Claude") makes Formora the place an AI assistant edits on the owner's behalf. That is a habit, and habits are sticky.

What could go wrong.

RISK	ANSWER
Big builders add the same AI features (Wix, Squarespace, Framer)	They will. They serve everyone, so they won't build job-specific designs, valuation tools for agents or a career Investigator. Compete on fit and price, not on general AI.
AI assistants make websites "unnecessary"	The opposite so far: AI needs sources to quote. A trustworthy page on your own domain becomes more valuable as fewer people click. Formora makes those pages.
Low price, thin profit	Pro is now \$6 a month: keep costs near zero, push yearly plans, offer free demo calls, and earn on Custom set-ups.
AI costs	Already handled: AI is sold at cost + 5% or runs on the customer's own key, with a hard daily budget for the free check.
Slow free-to-paid conversion	Measure it from day one in the console. Test what Pro unlocks; put the Investigator's first result in front of every new user.
Photo and content licensing	Sample photos are licensed (Unsplash) and kept out of downloads; customer content is theirs; the Investigator reads only the owner's own public pages, with consent.
Security incident	Pre-launch review done (docs/SECURITY.md). Keep dependencies updated monthly, two-factor on every outside account, daily off-server backups.

Prove the conversion, then pour on distribution.

Weeks 1–2

Launch on the server.
Approve the real estate templates. Set the done-for-you price and the legal name. Turn on two-factor everywhere.

Weeks 3–6

Post short demo videos for agents (the calculators, the door, the tower).
Publish job-title pages.
Watch sign-ups and conversion daily in the console.

Weeks 7–12

Talk to the first 20 paying customers. Double down on the job titles that convert; build the ChatGPT/Claude connector.

Numbers to watch

Free sign-ups a week · free-to-Pro conversion · yearly vs monthly mix · Investigator first checks run · done-for-you calls booked · Pro renewals.

Sources

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Market figures are third-party estimates and vary by source. Revenue scenarios are illustrations based on the stated assumptions, not forecasts or financial advice.